

Statewide Parent Child Care Financial Assistance User Experience Report



Report prepared for the California Department of Social Services by the
Child Care Resource Center
2024

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Executive Summary

The Child Care and Development Act, Assembly Bill No. 2960, was approved by Governor Newsom in September 2018. The purpose of AB 2960 is to provide a comprehensive, coordinated, and cost-effective system of child care and development services for children and families. It mandates the creation and maintenance of an online portal that provides comprehensive and up-to-date information on child care providers. The Child Care Resource Center (CCRC) was contracted by the California Department of Social Services (CDSS) to conduct a series of listening sessions with parents across all regions of California to gather valuable input about how to build an online resource that is compliant with AB 2960 and truly meets the needs of parents. The feedback obtained from these sessions is crucial in developing a platform that is intuitive, informative, and user-friendly for families seeking subsidized child care.

A mixed-methods approach grounded in human-centered design was used to conduct eight two-hour virtual listening sessions. Sessions were conducted in October and November 2023 and resulted in 60 participants. Recruitment was conducted across all regions of California. CCRC worked with a network of Resource and Referral agencies to facilitate recruitment into the listening sessions. A link to a recruitment survey was included (Appendix A) as a part of the messaging sent to families. Parents interested in participating in the listening sessions completed the recruitment survey, resulting in 1,142 parents completing the survey. Participants were categorized into distinct groups based on their responses to the survey questions and 927 parents qualified for the study after categorization. Parents were then randomly selected and contacted to participate in the listening sessions, with the objective of no more than 12 parents and no less than eight in each session. Every participant was administered an online survey through JotForm to collect additional quantitative and qualitative information in addition to the qualitative questions asked during the listening sessions. These questions were cross-referenced to the listening session questions in the analysis to provide additional information and categorization of variables which can be reviewed in the results section below.

The following results represent 60 participants across eight listening sessions. The results indicate many pain points for families seeking child care financial assistance and finding a provider that fits their unique needs. A minimum of 26 percent of all participants found it difficult or very difficult to find an agency or program to help them pay for child care, as well as resources to help them understand if they were eligible to receive assistance. One-third (34 percent) of all participants said it was either difficult or very difficult to find a child care provider. A majority (69 percent) of participants find out about financial assistance support via an interpersonal relationship or another social program from which they are receiving services. Only 17 percent of participants found out via an internet search. An online presence through Child Care Connect would reach more families and improve the equity and equality of access to knowledge since most knowledge is currently shared through interpersonal referrals and other social programs. Additionally, participants do not have a standardized way of finding out if they are eligible to receive financial assistance; 37 percent find out they are eligible because they are already receiving services from another social program, and 28 percent find out after they applied to the program. Once parents navigate the barriers around finding and applying for financial assistance they are faced with another barrier, being placed on a waitlist to receive financial assistance; 67 percent of participants were placed on a waitlist for financial assistance for child care and 16 percent were on the waitlist for over six

months. It is no surprise that over 40 percent of parents spoke specifically about the struggles with being placed on a waitlist since there is no standardization of regular status updates to which parents have easy access; specifically, 29 percent of parents spoke about experiencing stress from the uncertainty of how long they would be on the wait list and the need to reduce wait times. Additionally, 50 percent of participants spoke about needing regular updates to their waitlist status.

After navigating the complex difficulties presented to parents in finding out about financial assistance agencies and programs, eligibility, applying, and encountering a waitlist, parents then find themselves in the difficult situation of needing to find a child care provider that meets their unique needs. Parents do not have a centralized hub for searching for providers that work for them, including all important factors they used to decide on a provider. Almost half (46 percent) of parents found their child care provider through an interpersonal referral (personal contact). Additionally, the two most important factors parents look for when choosing a provider (also the most difficult to find when searching), were location and hours of operation with 91 percent and 78 percent of participants responding. And while the majority of participants start their search with the referral list provided to them, they find it outdated and inconclusive, often missing many available child care providers in their area. Parents need a comprehensive website where they can easily navigate the important factors they have outlined in this report.

The following recommendations aim to relieve the challenges parents outlined in their journey to successfully find, apply, and enroll their child in subsidized child care: Exhaustive marketing and other means of promotion are needed for the online portal Child Care Connect so all parents have equal access to information on subsidized child care. Parents then need the ability to enter an address to find their local Resource & Referral and Alternative Payment Plan agencies that serve them and all child care providers in their area. Standardized information on child care providers is needed to ensure each includes the most important factors parents look for when researching providers, including clear information presented by each child care provider on accepting child care financial assistance. Implementing a process to ensure all information on the website is accurate and up to date. Parents also need an opportunity to engage with providers via multiple avenues (phone, email, and chat features). It is recommended that the website also include an eligibility screening tool that parents can use to determine if they qualify for child care financial assistance. Also recommended is for the website to provide an estimated amount of time one should expect to be on the wait list after parents apply and provide regular updates on their wait list status. If this is not possible due to the variables and changes to the waitlist, then the online portal should provide education to help parents understand why it is difficult to explain their status on the waitlist. Lastly, the online portal should have a feature that saves previously completed filled out information by parents when submitting their application into the program and autofill into future documentation to reduce challenges parents face in the amount of documentation they need to complete.

It is evident families seeking child care support face many complex struggles at multiple points in their journey to access child care financial assistance and find a provider that fits their needs. There is an urgent need for an accessible, user-friendly online platform that addresses each of the challenges outlined in this report. Recommendations for future research to help provide additional information in

support of building the Child Care Connect website include the following: Involving a broader demographic in future listening sessions, specifically holding listening sessions with parents identifying as men and non-binary and holding listening sessions with parents that speak other primary languages in each region in California other than English and Spanish. Additionally, conducting user experience (UX) testing with both parents and child care providers could offer valuable feedback. Lastly, enhancing collaboration with Resource and Referral and other Alternative Payment Plan agencies.

Introduction

This report details the findings from a series of listening sessions. This report is a key component of an initiative to refine and enhance the online child care resources provided by the California Department of Social Services (CDSS), particularly the website Child Care Connect. The purpose of these sessions was to deeply engage with parents who have firsthand experience in navigating the child care financial assistance system and finding child care providers. The objective of this project was to gather their valuable insights to inform and improve the functionality and user-friendliness of online resources, making them more responsive to the actual needs of families seeking child care support.

In the course of this project, the Child Care Resource Center (CCRC) was contracted to reach out to a diverse group of parents, all of whom had interacted with the child care financial assistance system in various capacities. These sessions were not just about collecting data; they were about listening to stories, understanding struggles, and celebrating the small victories that parents experience in their journey through the child care system. Participants shared their experiences with the application process for child care subsidies, the challenges they faced in finding suitable providers, and their overall interaction with the existing online resources. This first-hand feedback provided invaluable insights into the practical realities that parents face, beyond what any theoretical model could offer.

The depth and breadth of the discussions in these sessions have been instrumental in shaping our understanding of the gaps in the current system and the areas where improvements are most needed. Parents' suggestions ranged from simplifying the application process for subsidies to enhancing the search functionality for finding providers on the website. These insights will not only guide the technical enhancements of the online platform but also assist in rethinking the approach to supporting parents in their child care journey.

Bill AB2960

California Assembly Bill 2960 (Statutes of 2018) set forth specific requirements regarding the dissemination of information about child care and development services. It mandates the creation and maintenance of an online portal that provides comprehensive and up-to-date information on child care providers, including but not limited to, licensing status, health and safety information, and quality indicators. The essence of AB 2960 is to ensure transparency, accessibility, and ease of understanding for families seeking child care services.

This report on listening sessions were a direct response to these requirements. The sessions were designed to gather input from parents to inform the development of an online resource that is not only compliant with AB 2960 but also goes beyond compliance to truly meet the needs of parents. The feedback obtained from these sessions is crucial in fulfilling the requirements of AB 2960 in developing an intuitive, informative, and user-friendly child care platform.

Insights into what families are looking for in an online child care portal were gained by engaging with parents directly. This includes understanding their preferences in terms of the type and depth of information needed, the accessibility of the platform, and how they wish to navigate through it to find relevant information. The project, therefore, not only aligns with the AB 2960 requirements in providing essential information about child care services but also ensures that this information is presented in a way that is most useful and accessible to the families who need it the most.

Methodology

Research Design

Prior research has been conducted on parent user experiences which informed the development of this study. A comprehensive needs assessment was conducted in 2019 on the statewide early learning and care system. Findings from this study cited issues with availability of care, frustration with waiting lists for child care financial assistance, and concerns on quality that distilled down into parents needing more information on the programs they apply for and providers they choose for their child care.

The listening sessions were informed by this research and conducted to gather information on how families engage with early care and learning (ECL) systems, specifically: (1) engaging with Resource & Referral and Alternative Payment agencies, (2) entering the subsidized child care system, and (3) finding a child care provider. These three areas of investigation were based on legislative requirements (AB 2960) for the CDSS to build improvements into their online ECL portal, Child Care Connect. These legislative requirements were classified into five domains.

ECL Portal Improvement Domain	Connected Listening Session Questions
A) Information on ELC programs	(1), (2), (5)
B) The opportunity to connect with ELC providers	(1), (3), (7), (8)
C) The ability to use an online eligibility screening tool to assess eligibility for ELC services	(2), (4), (5)
D) A way to connect with local R&R agencies and Alternative Payment agencies to help with assessing and selecting child care options	(1), (2), (3), (7), (8), (9)
E) Access to placement on waiting lists for subsidized child care programs	(1), (4), (5), (6)

Questions for the listening sessions were designed to gather information on each domain to provide a complete picture of a family's journey through the various early care and learning systems. The information gathered provided guidance on how an online early care and learning portal could be designed to reduce or eliminate pain points throughout their journey and provide valuable information to families based on these five domains.

Listening Session Questions	Connected Domains
1. How did you find out that child care financial assistance was available?	A, B, D, E
2. How did you find out that you were eligible to receive child care financial assistance?	A, C, D
3. How did you discover the agency that provided you with child care financial assistance?	B, D
4. What were the steps you had to take to apply for child care financial assistance?	C, E
5. How do you think your experience applying for child care financial assistance could have been improved?	A, C, E
6. If you encountered a waiting list, how do you feel about the process of being placed on the list?	E
7. What tools or resources did you use to find your child care provider? (e.g. internet search, Yelp, R&R referral, friend, or family referral)	B, D
8. What was important to you when making a decision on which child care provider to leave your child or children with?	B, D
9. What kinds of information would be useful for you to have in an online website for understanding child care options and finding child care? (such as mychildcareplan.org)	D
10. Is there anything else you would recommend that we haven't talked about?	A, B, C, D, E

In addition to the qualitative questions asked during the listening sessions, every participant was administered an online survey through JotForm to collect additional information. This survey included questions on demographics such as age, Likert scale questions on their subsidized child care experiences, and other questions regarding their experiences searching for child care providers. These questions were cross-referenced to the listening session questions in the analysis to provide additional information and categorization of variables. A full list of survey and listening session questions can be found in Appendices B-D.

Recruitment

Recruitment was conducted across all regions of California to represent the diverse cultures and communities of the state. CCRC developed messaging for agencies to recruit parents into the listening sessions. CCRC worked to effectively communicate this messaging with regional lead agencies – a network of Resource & Referral (R&R) and Alternative Payment Plan agencies based on region, with a lead agency in charge of communicating across all R&Rs in their respective regions. Regional lead agencies were provided the recruitment messaging to distribute to their regional R&Rs who then shared them with families in their communities. This messaging was distributed either via e-mail or paper flyer. The R&R distributing the messaging was given the ultimate discretion on messaging, as they are best suited to understand their community and how to maximize outreach to parents. A full list of regional leads and their respective regions can be found in Appendix E.

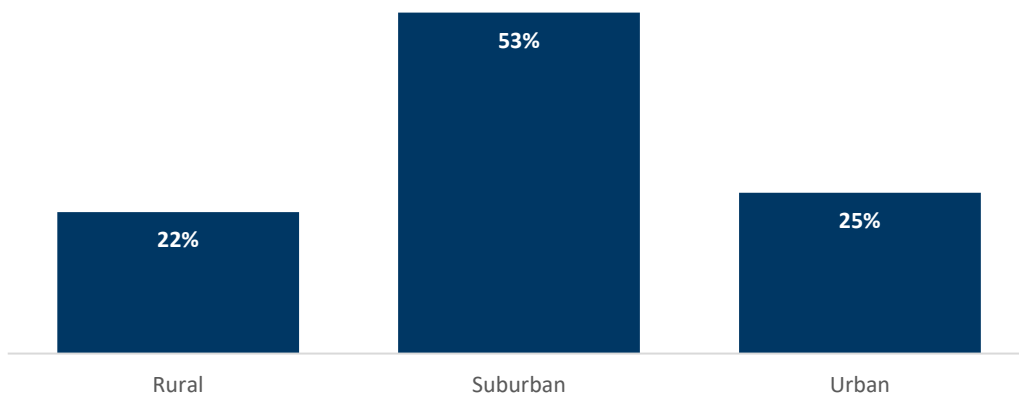
As a part of the messaging sent to families, a link to a recruitment survey was included (Appendix A). Parents who called or emailed with interest in participating in the listening sessions were asked to complete the recruitment survey. This survey included questions on demographics as well as the recruitment qualification criteria of having experience with receiving child care financial assistance. Participants were categorized into distinct groups based on their responses to the first survey question, "Have you ever used or applied for child care financial assistance?" Group One comprised individuals who answered "Yes, I am currently receiving it," Group Two included those who responded with "Yes, I've received it in the past," Group Three encompassed respondents who selected options such as "I've completed an application but have been put on a waitlist or I've applied in the past but was declined," and Group Five consisted of individuals who chose "No." Respondents who selected "I'm not sure" were not included in the study.

For this study's purposes, participants were randomly selected from Group One. Applicants to the study in Group One were representative of the population and diverse demographics across California. The randomly selected applicants subsequently were contacted via email and phone based on the contact information provided in the recruitment survey. The outreach process consisted of selecting 12 distinct individuals from Group One for each of the eight listening sessions.

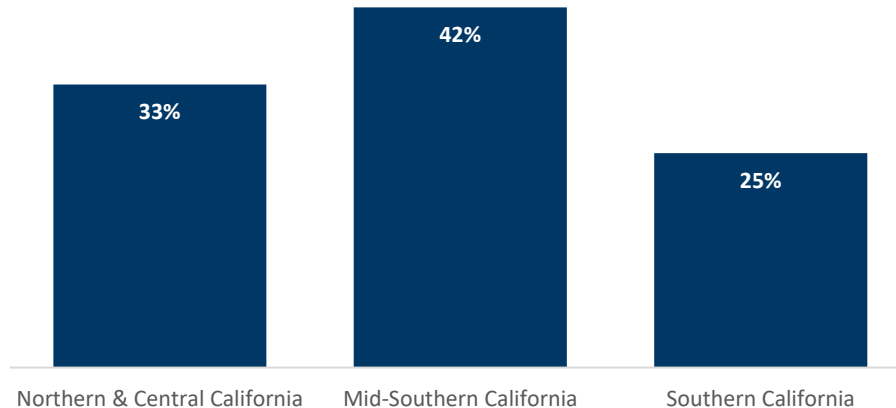
Recruited participants were given multiple reminders about their inclusion in the listening session to improve retention rates. The first participation reminder was sent via e-mail one week prior to their listening session. The second and third reminders were conducted by phone one day before the listening session and one hour before it. If individuals did not respond to the e-mail then two phone call attempts were made to confirm their participation and inform them that they would be dropped from the study if they did not reply with confirmation. If the research team could not confirm their attendance after the second phone call, they were informed that they were dropped, and a new participant was randomly selected within Group One.

Ultimately, the study reached 1,142 of parents who applied for the study. Nine hundred twenty-seven parents qualified for the study as a part of Group One. Finally, the study achieved a total participant count of 60 individuals across eight listening sessions for an average of seven and five tenths participants per session. The demographic distribution revealed that 22 percent of participants resided in rural areas, 53 percent in suburban areas, and the remaining 25 percent in urban areas. Geographically, 33 percent of participants were from Northern and Central California, 42 percent from the Mid-Southern region, and the final 25 percent from Southern California.

Participants resided in all **community types**



Participants resided in all **state regions**



Household density and zip code tabulation areas (ZCTA) from the US Census were used to determine community type. The number of household units per square mile within a ZCTA determined if the zip code was urban, suburban, or rural¹. ZCTA's with 102 or less households per square mile were labeled "rural". ZCTA's with 2,213 or more households per square mile were labeled "urban". ZCTA's with a household density between 102 and 2,213 were labeled "suburban". The zip code in which participants lived determined which community type they were from.

The four regions of the California Continuation Education Association defined the state regions used for this study. Northern California consisted of 35 counties, Central California was made up of 13 counties, and Mid-Southern and Southern California each comprised five counties. The full list of counties present in each region is available in Appendix E.

Listening Sessions

In the approach to administering the listening sessions, the focus was on creating an interactive and confidential environment where participants could share their experiences with child care financial assistance and finding child care providers. This approach was geared towards gathering insightful feedback to enhance the California Department of Social Services' child care website, Child Care Connect.

Each session began with the Introduction Phase. It started with a warm introduction, where the team members identified their roles - a lead facilitator to guide the conversation, an aide to handle technical issues and monitor the chat for text-based participation, and a note-taker to accurately record the feedback without participating in the discussions. Participants were encouraged to use video feeds to foster a more personal and engaging environment.

The next part of each listening session was the Establishing Group Norms Phase. Confidentiality was emphasized and the importance of using aggregate data for reporting, ensuring that individual participants and their interactions remained anonymous. Participation was facilitated through various methods: speaking up by unmuting microphones, using hand-raising features in Zoom for orderly turn-taking, and typing responses in the chat, which the aide would voice periodically.

The Engagement Phase was the third phase and the majority of each listening session. The phase started with an icebreaker, allowing participants to introduce themselves and share a bit about their personal lives. This was followed by an extensive discussion, lasting between 70 to 90 minutes, driven by carefully crafted questions and probes. These questions were designed to elicit detailed insights into participants' experiences with child care financial assistance, the application process, challenges faced, resources used to find child care providers, and suggestions for improving online resources for child care options.

Every listening session ended with the Debriefing Phase. The study team expressed gratitude during the debriefing for the participants' contributions and offered a space for any lingering questions or concerns. Participants were informed about the follow-up process, including the distribution of gift cards as a token of appreciation for their time and participation.

¹ Methodology for defining reasons: <https://fivethirtyeight.com/features/how-suburban-are-big-american-cities/>

This approach was crafted to ensure that the feedback collected was comprehensive, authentic, and directly reflective of the experiences of those who have navigated the child care financial assistance system. The insights gained are invaluable in enhancing the online resources available to parents seeking child care support, aligning closely with the needs and preferences of our target audience.

The listening sessions conducted exemplify the application of human-centered design (HCD) by focusing on empathy and user experience. The sessions were structured to deeply understand the experiences and challenges of parents navigating the child care financial assistance system, providing direct insights into their needs. This empathetic approach ensures that the website's design is grounded in real-life user experiences, aligning closely with their actual needs and preferences.

The sessions showcased the iterative nature of HCD, where feedback is continuously integrated into the design process. Various participation methods, such as speaking, chat functions, and hand-raising, were employed to accommodate different communication preferences, ensuring inclusivity. Additionally, sessions were held with Spanish as the spoken language to promote inclusivity in the study. This approach allowed for a diverse range of voices to be heard, making the design process more comprehensive and user-centric.

Lastly, the emphasis on confidentiality and creating a safe space for honest feedback is a hallmark of HCD, fostering trust and encouraging open communication. This trust-building aspect is crucial for obtaining genuine insights, which are pivotal in developing a user-centered and empathetic design for the child care information resource. These sessions, therefore, effectively utilized HCD principles to ensure the final design is not only functional but also deeply resonant with the needs and experiences of its users - the parents.

Limitations

This study achieved a remarkable overall participant turnout, reflecting a strong interest and engagement in early learning and care activities. However, it is important to acknowledge certain limitations in the demographic representation of the participants. Notably, efforts to include primary language speaking individuals for languages other than English and Spanish were less successful than anticipated. The turnout of non-English and non-Spanish primary speakers was insufficient to form a separate group despite working with a third-party company to provide interpretation services in anticipation of these groups. Consequently, the feasibility of employing live translation for a very small number of participants (one-two individuals) was limited.

Another notable limitation was the gender imbalance among participants both in the recruitment pool and the listening session participants with participants identifying as female being the majority. This imbalance was also similarly represented in the study's recruitment pool. Efforts were made to include a diverse and equitable gender pool of people during session recruitment, but this disproportionate representation limits the diversity of perspectives and may affect the generalizability of findings across different genders.

A critical factor contributing to this limitation was the time constraints under which the study operated. The research design, sessions, and analysis took place in five months. These constraints not only affected the duration and scheduling of the sessions but also the ability to effectively reach and recruit a more diverse participant pool. The perspectives and experiences of non-English and non-Spanish primary speaking individuals, men, and non-binary individuals may be underrepresented in the findings because of time constraints. This underrepresentation might limit the applicability and generalizability of results to those communities.

Efforts were made to mitigate this impact, including outreach attempts to these communities, but these efforts did not yield the desired increase in participation from these demographic groups. It is clear from this experience that future studies would benefit from extended recruitment periods, more targeted and outreach strategies, and collaborations with community groups and organizations within these communities to get feedback on recruitment strategies to ensure better representation and participation.

In conclusion, while this study has provided valuable insights, it also highlights the importance of continually striving for inclusive research practices. Learning from the limitations of this study, future research should aim to implement more effective strategies for engaging underrepresented groups, thereby enriching the research with a greater diversity of perspectives and experiences.

Findings

Basic Results

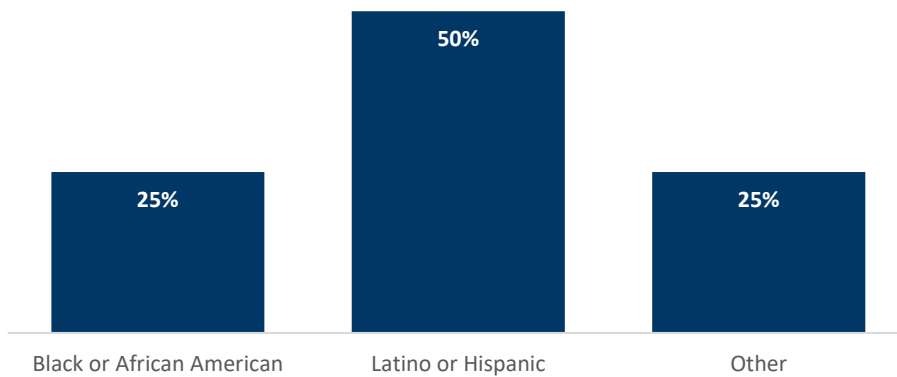
The following represents data obtained from the JotForm survey completed by parents who attended a listening session and reflects responses from 58 parents, as two parents did not complete the survey.

All four identified regional focus areas were represented in the listening sessions. Examining regional demographics, 33 percent of participants lived in Northern and Central California, 42 percent in Mid-Southern California, and the remaining 25 percent in Southern California.

Additionally, all three identified area types were represented. The demographic profile of participants in the listening sessions was: 22 percent resided in rural settings, 53 percent in suburban areas, and the remaining 25 percent in urban environments.

Parents were asked to disclose their ethnic and racial identification via a check all that apply function. Responses were then categorized into the five categories displayed. Responses reflect a diverse sample, with 50 percent identifying as Latino/a or Hispanic, 25 percent as Black or African-American, and 25 percent as Other.

Participants represented the **racial and ethnic diversity** of California



All age range categories were represented in the listening sessions. Fifty-eight percent fell within the 26-35 age group and forty-two percent were in other age ranges.

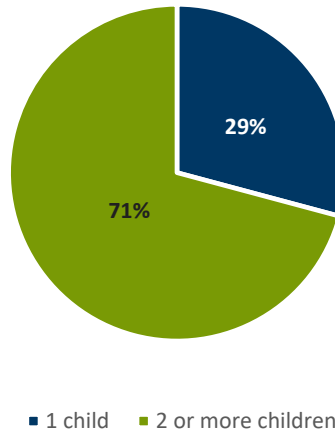
Most participants were between **ages 26 and 35 years**



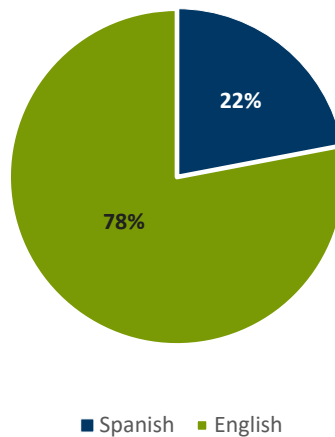
Inquiring about family structure, parents were asked how many children for whom they were the primary caretaker. Results were categorized into having one child or having two or more children. Most parents had two or more children at 68 percent, while the remaining 28 percent reported having only one child.

Additionally, six listening sessions were conducted in English and two listening sessions were conducted in Spanish. This resulted in 78 percent of parents completing a listening session in English, and the remaining 22 percent of parents completing the listening sessions in Spanish.

Most participants had **2 or more children**



Participants spoke either **English or Spanish**



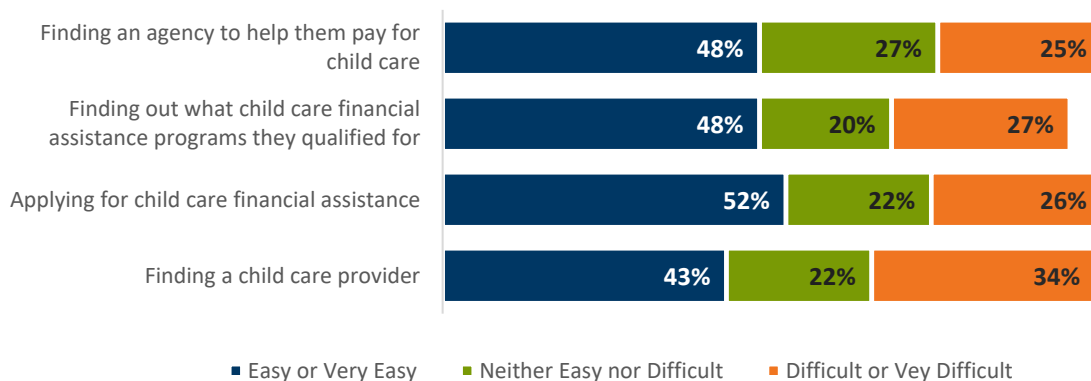
Gender distribution demonstrated that most participants identified as female.

An online survey via JotForm was distributed to all participants who attended a listening session, as described at the beginning of this section. The survey was offered in both English and Spanish, inquired

about parent’s experiences in finding a child care provider, important factors when choosing a provider, and perceptions of difficulty and/or ease in navigating the financial assistance program process, as well as in selecting a provider. The following data represents responses from 58 out of the 60 total participants, as two participants did not complete the family experiences survey.

Participants were asked to give their perceptions of ease or difficulty in navigating the child care financial assistance program and finding a child care provider. Participants were asked four questions and to rank each of these questions on a Likert scale of very difficult, difficult, neither easy nor difficult, easy, and very easy. The responses very difficult and difficult, as well as easy and very easy were combined. Half or fewer participants ranked all categories as easy or very easy, showing room for improvement across all four categories. Participants ranked applying for child care financial assistance as the easiest at 52 percent. While the most difficult category for participants was finding a child care provider, with 34 percent of participants responding very difficult or difficult. A national goal in this area is to ensure easy access to child care and therefore these results could be improved²

Participants' perception of **ease and difficulty** in navigating financial assistance and finding a provider

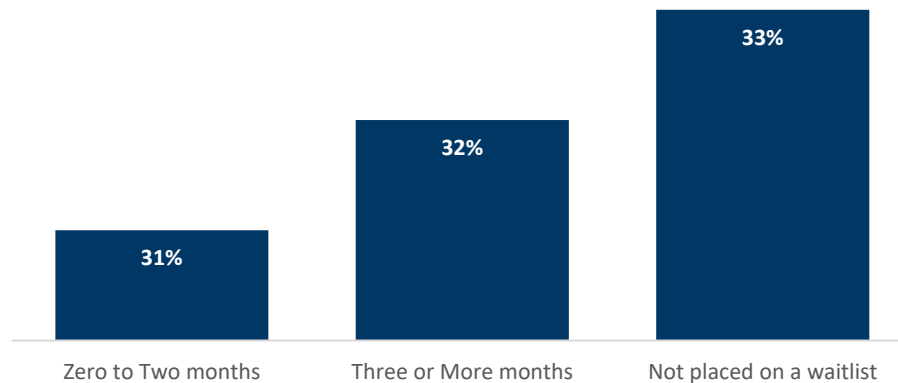


Participants were asked, “If you were placed on a waitlist, about how long were you on the waitlist before receiving financial assistance?” Most participants, 67 percent, were placed on a waitlist, while the remaining 33 percent were not placed on a waitlist. Almost one-third (31 percent) of those placed on a

² A July 2023 notice of proposed rulemaking “proposes ways for CCDF Lead Agencies to streamline eligibility and enrollment processes so families can receive child care assistance faster and so program bureaucracy is less likely to disrupt parent employment, training, and education and impede access to child care.”
<https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2023/07/13/2023-14290/improving-child-care-access-affordability-and-stability-in-the-child-care-and-development-fund-ccdf>

waitlist spent under three months on the waitlist, and 32 percent spent over three months on the waitlist.

Two-thirds of participants **were placed on a waitlist** before receiving financial assistance

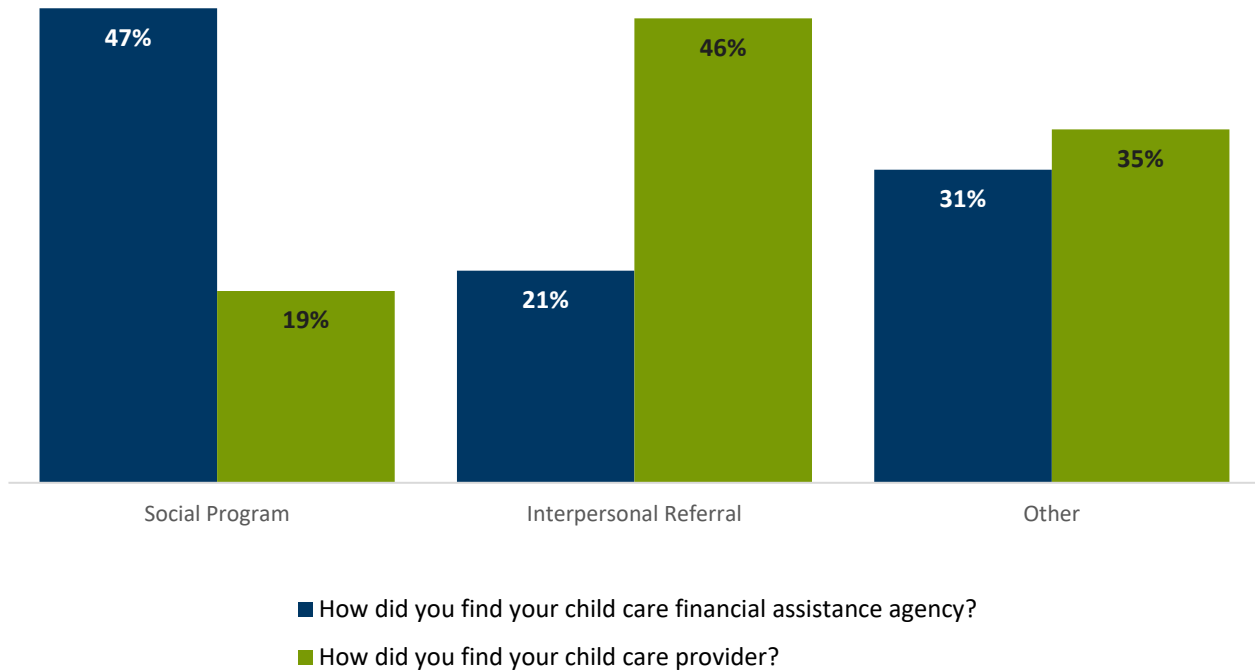


Participants were asked "When applying for child care financial assistance, how helpful were the staff guiding you through the application process?" Almost three-quarters (72 percent) of participants responded that staff were helpful or very helpful.

Participants were asked "How did you find your child care provider?" and "How did you find your child care financial assistance agency?" The plurality of participants, 46 percent, found their child care provider through an interpersonal referral, either a friend, family member, co-worker, or any other personal contact. While 47 percent found out about their child care financial assistance program through another social program referral such as CalWORKs (California Work Opportunity and Responsibility for Kids) or TANF (Temporary Assistance for Needy Families). Similar results were found in a landscape study of home-based child care in Los Angeles County.³

³ <https://www.ccala.net/wp-content/uploads/2023/06/CCALA-HBCC-Landscape-Analysis-2023.pdf>

Participants found their **financial assistance agency** and their **child care provider** through various means

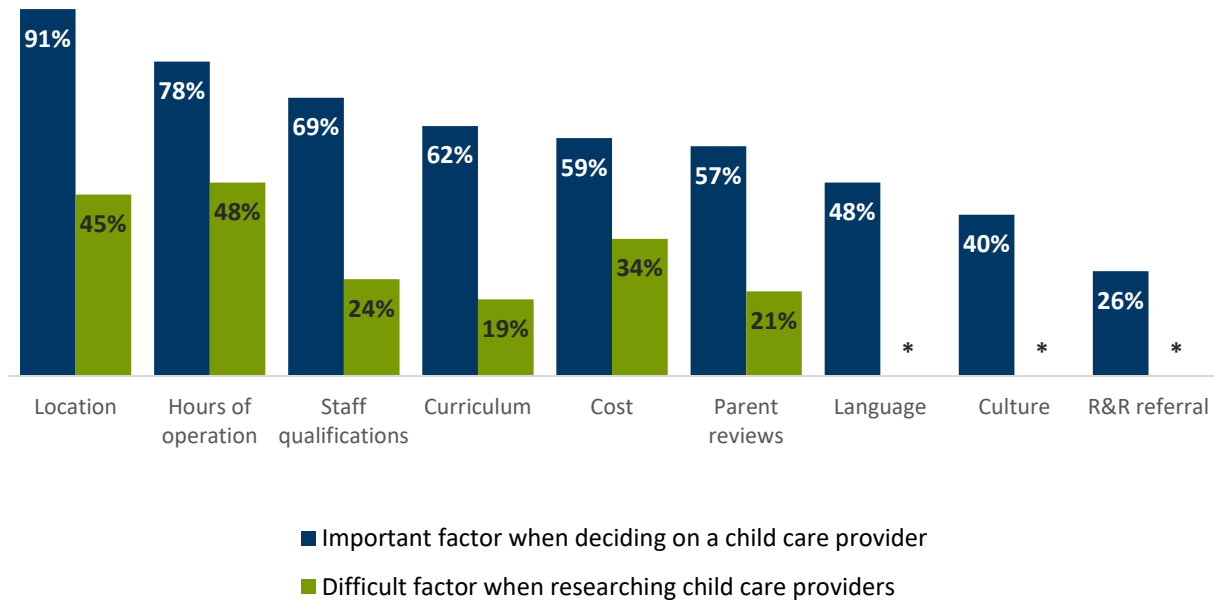


Child care decision-making is a complex process.⁴ Prior research with parents who selected home-based providers in Los Angeles County found location and hours as among the top three factors in the child care search.⁵ Participants were asked, “What factors are important for you when deciding on a child care provider?” and “Which of these factors were difficult for you to find when researching child care providers?” The two most important factors were location and hours of operation with 91 percent and 78 percent of participants responding. These two factors were also the most common factors respondents indicated that were difficult in finding when searching for a provider. Hours of operation had 48 percent of participants saying it was difficult to find, and location has 45 percent of participants saying it was difficult to find. Conversely, 62 percent of participants indicated that curriculum was an important factor, but only 19 percent indicated this was difficult to find when researching different child care providers.

⁴ <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=ED517546>
https://www.acf.hhs.gov/sites/default/files/documents/opre/child_care_decision_making_literature_review_pdf_version_v2.pdf

⁵ <https://www.ccala.net/wp-content/uploads/2023/06/CCALA-HBCC-Landscape-Analysis-2023.pdf>

Location and hours of operation were the **most important** and also the **most difficult** factors when finding a provider



Participants were asked to rank their satisfaction with their child care provider. Participants ranked this from very unsatisfied to very satisfied. Most (91 percent) participants replied that they were very satisfied or satisfied with their child care provider.

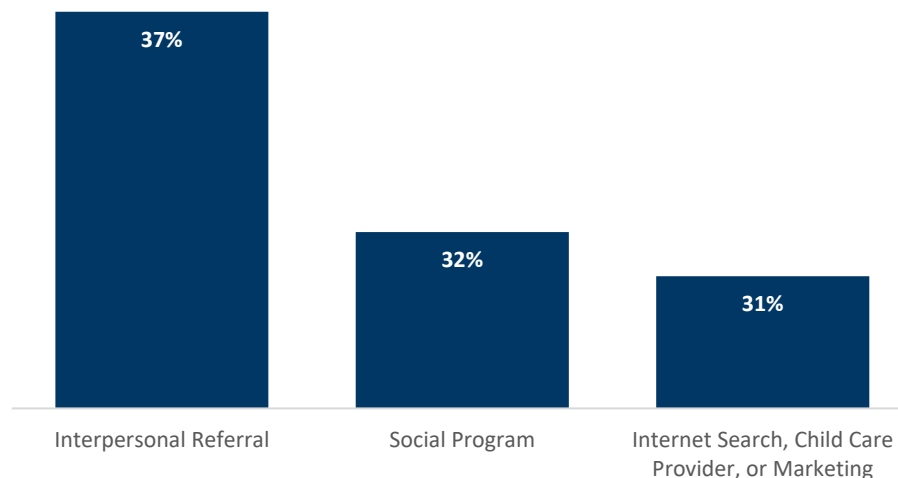
Listening Sessions

Eight two-hour virtual listening sessions were conducted in October and November 2023 with 60 participants. The largest listening session group had 11 participants. Each session consisted of an introduction, developing group norms, an icebreaker question, ten discussion questions and a debriefing. The introduction provided background information to participants and allowed CCRC staff to introduce themselves and their roles during the listening sessions. Three CCRC staff were present at each listening session to fill the following three roles: Facilitator, note taker, and technical assistance. Developing group norms was an opportunity to set the tone of the session, ensuring all participants felt safe and had an opportunity to share. Lastly, an icebreaker was used to encourage participants to participate and gave an opportunity for the technical assistance staff to help participants troubleshoot any issues they were having before starting the discussion questions. The following section summarizes responses provided by participants for each of the ten discussion questions. The percentages listed denote general differences noticed, as statistical analysis was not conducted due to low cell sizes. Survey data from the online family experiences survey completed by participants was analyzed and included where relevant to highlight any trends noted.

QUESTION ONE- Learning About Child Care Financial Assistance

For the first question, participants were asked “How did you find out that child care financial assistance was available?” The largest group (37 percent) of participants said they found out through an interpersonal referral, such as a family member, a friend, or a coworker. Closely behind, 32 percent of participants said they learned through a social program, meaning they were already involved in another program like CalWORKs and found out through that program that they may qualify for child care financial assistance. An additional 31 percent of participants said they found out through either: (1) an internet search, either through general search engines like Google or through particular child care websites, (2) through a child care provider, or (3) through marketing, such as newsletters or flyers.

Interpersonal referrals and social programs were the **top ways** participants found out that child care financial assistance was available



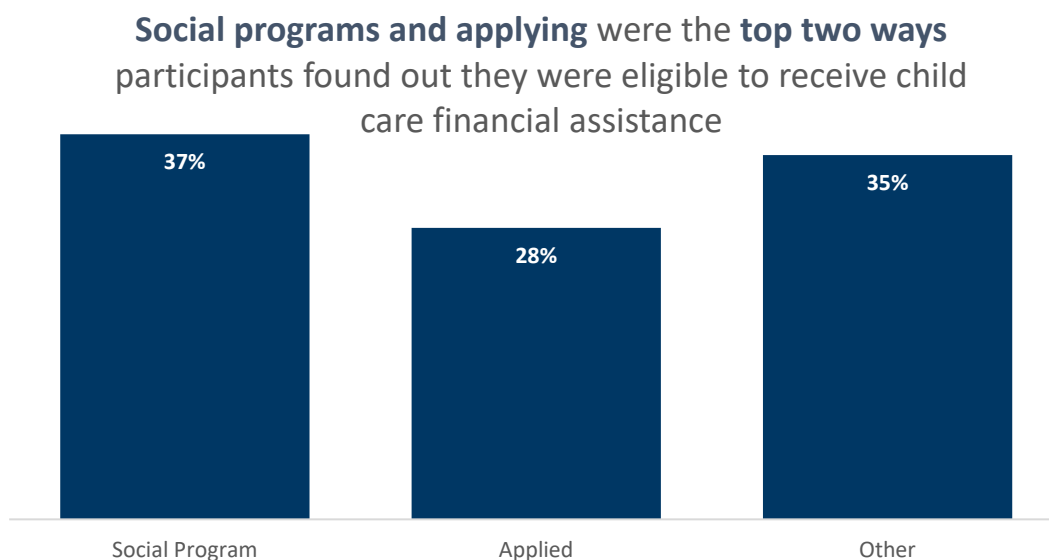
Differences by region were examined and participants from central California were more likely to find out about child care financial assistance through an interpersonal referral, with 67 percent of participants saying so compared to 36 percent of participants from mid-Southern California, 27 percent of participants from Northern California and 27 percent of participants from Southern California. Participants from Southern California were more likely to have found out through a social program, with 47 percent of participants saying so compared to 33 percent of participants from Central California, 28 percent of participants from Mid-Southern California, and 18 percent of participants from Northern California. Similarly, participants from Southern California were more likely than participants from other regions to have found out through a child care provider.

Differences by area type were examined and participants from suburban areas were more likely to have found out about child care financial assistance through an internet search, with 28 percent of participants saying so compared to * percent of participants from urban areas and zero percent of participants from rural areas. Similarly, participants from suburban areas were more likely to have found

out through marketing, with * percent of participants saying so compared to zero percent of participants from both urban and rural areas.

QUESTION TWO – Eligibility for Child Care Financial Assistance

For the second question, participants were asked “How did you find out that you were eligible to receive child care financial assistance?” Many (37 percent) participants said they found out through a social program, such as the county or an R&R agency. Another 28 percent of participants said they found out through applying for child care financial assistance itself and * percent of participants said they found out through the internet, either through search engines and their results or using online tools like child care cost calculators. The remaining * percent found out in the follow ways: * percent of participants said they found out through a child care provider; * percent of participants said they found out through an interpersonal connection such as a family member, a friend, or a coworker; * percent of participants said they found out by going in-person to an agency and inquiring.



When examining responses by region, participants from Central California were more likely to have found out they were eligible to receive child care financial assistance from a social program, with 56 percent of participants saying so compared to 40 percent of participants from Southern California, 32 percent of participants from Mid-Southern California, and 27 percent of participants from Northern California. Participants from Northern California were more likely to have found out through applying, with 46 percent of participants saying so compared to 39 percent of participants from Mid-Southern and Central California, and 27 percent of participants from Southern California.

Participants with one child were more likely to have found out they were eligible to receive child care financial assistance from a social program, with 47 percent saying so compared to 32 percent of

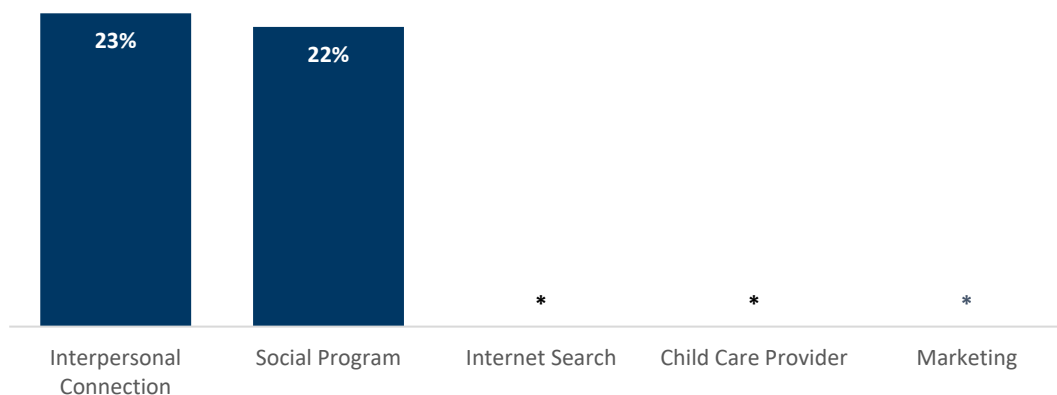
participants with two children or more. Inversely, participants with two or more children were more likely to say they found out through applying, with 37 percent of participants saying so.

Looking at participants' view on how helpful staff were in guiding them through the application process, participants who viewed staff as "helpful" were more likely to have found out they were eligible to receive child care financial assistance through a social program, with 43 percent of participants saying so compared to 20 percent of participants who viewed staff as "neither helpful nor unhelpful" and 17 percent of participants who viewed staff as "unhelpful". Conversely, participants who viewed staff as "unhelpful" or "neither helpful nor unhelpful" were more likely to have found out through applying, with 50 percent of participants saying so for each compared to 21 percent of participants who viewed staff as "helpful". Similarly, participants who viewed staff as "unhelpful" or "neither helpful nor unhelpful" were more likely to have found out through the internet, with * percent and * percent respectively saying so compared to * percent of participants who viewed staff as "helpful".

QUESTION THREE – Connecting With R&R/APP Agencies

For the third question, participants were asked "How did you discover the agency that provided you with child care financial assistance?". There was approximately one-quarter (23 percent) of participants that said they discovered the agency through interpersonal connections, such a friend, a family member, or a coworker, while 22 percent of participants said they discovered the agency through a social program like CalWORKs. An additional * percent of participants said they discovered the agency through an internet search, while * percent of participants said they discovered the agency through a provider and * percent of participants said they discovered the agency through marketing, such as a newsletter or flyer.

Interpersonal connections and social programs were the **top two ways** participants discovered the agency that provided them financial assistance



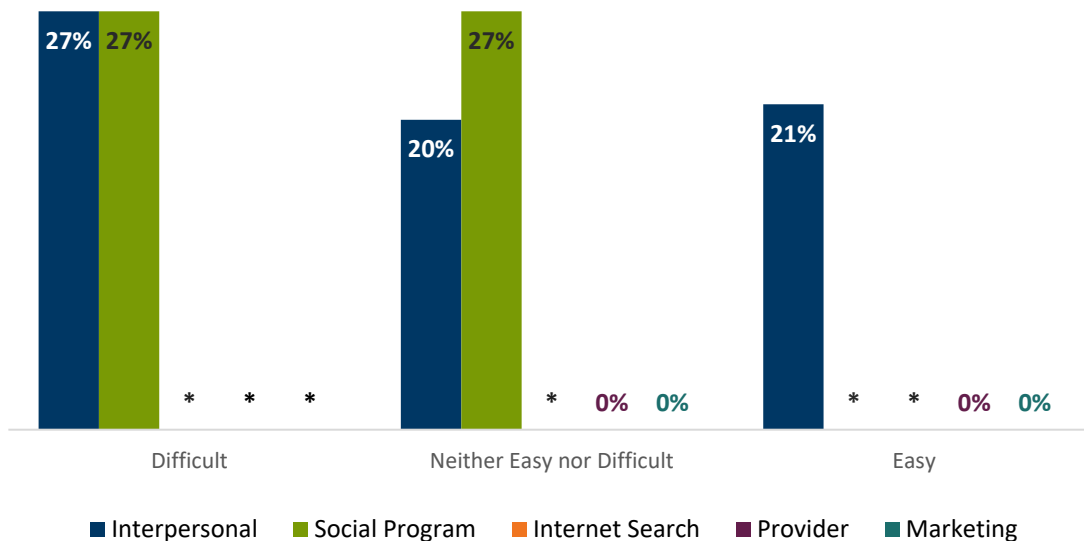
Differences by area type were examined and participants from rural areas were more likely to have discovered the agency that provided them with child care financial assistance through a social program (23 percent) or an internet search (23 percent). Participants from suburban areas were more likely to

have discovered the agency through an interpersonal connection (28 percent), followed by a social program (22 percent). Participants from urban areas were more likely to have discovered the agency through an interpersonal connection (20 percent) and a social program (20 percent).

Differences by language were examined and participants who spoke Spanish were more likely to have found out about the agency that provided them with child care financial assistance through an interpersonal connection, with 39 percent of participants saying so compared to 19 percent of participants who spoke English.

Participants who found it “difficult”, “easy”, and “neither easy nor difficult” to find an agency to help pay for child care all found out about the agency at similar rates through an interpersonal connection (27 percent, 21 percent, and 20 percent respectively), at somewhat similar rates through a social program (27 percent, * percent, and 27 percent respectively), and at the same rate through an internet search (each at seven percent). However, participants who found it “difficult” to find an agency were the only ones to have found the agency through a provider (* percent) and through marketing (* percent) while zero percent of participants who found it “easy” or “neither easy nor difficult” found the agency through these means.

Participants who found it "difficult" to find an agency to help them pay for child care **were more likely to discover the agency through a provider or marketing**

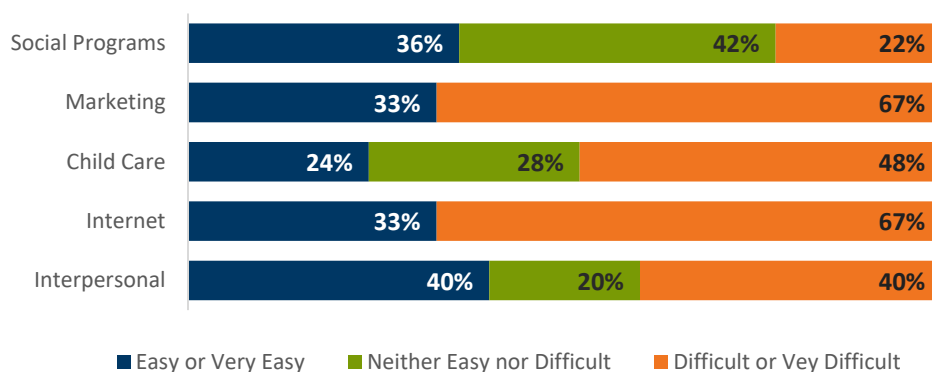


QUESTION FOUR – Journeys in Applying for Child Care Financial Assistance

Participants were asked “What were the steps you had to take to apply for child care financial assistance?” When analyzing how a participant finds out about child care financial assistance (where

they start the process of applying) and their perceptions of ease and difficulty in applying for the financial assistance program, it is apparent that the starting place matters. Participants who find out and start with a personal connection through an interpersonal referral or via another social program like CalWORKs have the highest rates of those indicating that the process to apply was either very easy or easy, with Interpersonal at 40 percent and Social programs at 36 percent.

Participants found it the easiest to discover financial assistance through an interpersonal referral



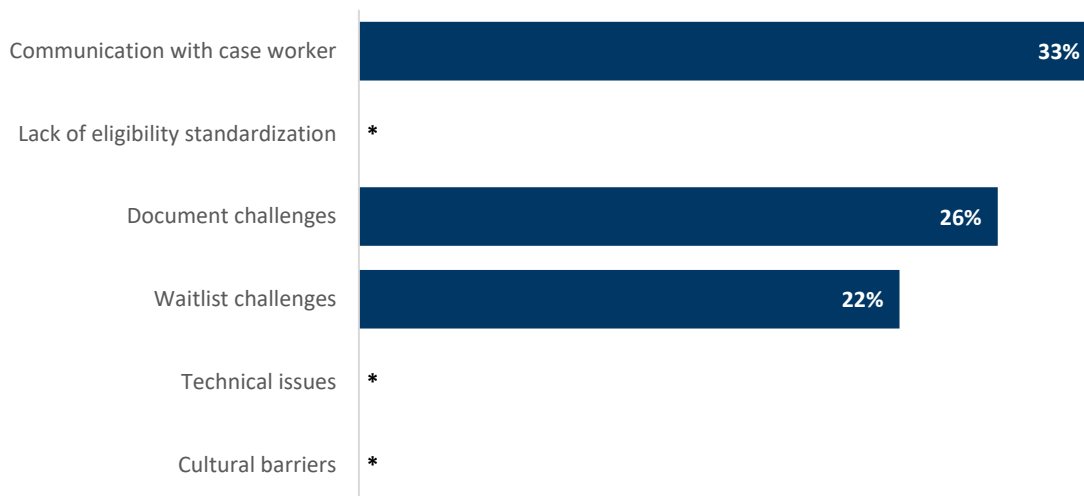
“I’m so grateful that my experience applying for child care financial assistance has been awesome because my case worker supported me all the way through.”

– Participant

QUESTION FOUR-A – Challenges Encountered

Participants were also asked “What were the steps you had to take to apply for child care financial assistance, and what challenges if any did you encounter?” Participants were asked about challenges during the child care financial assistance process. This prompt had a response rate of more than half with 52 percent of the 60 participants responding to the question. About a third or 30 percent reported that communication with their caseworker was a challenge during the child care financial assistance process, with * percent reporting that documentation was a challenge either because of the amount of paperwork or submitting paperwork. Percentages do not sum to 100 percent since some participants are counted more than once because they provided multiple responses to more than one of the subcodes.

The **most common challenge** when applying for financial assistance was **communication with case worker**



Looking at region type, participants from northern and southern California areas were more likely to have responded to encountering challenges with the child care financial assistance process, with 55 percent and 67 percent of participants respectively saying so compared to 36 percent of participants from the mid-southern California area and 33 percent of participants from the central California region. While no one from central or northern California said the documentation required to be submitted was a burden or challenge, and 43 percent of participants from the southern California and mid southern regions said it was a challenge.

Looking at language type, 62 percent of English speakers responded to encountering a challenge with the child care financial assistance process compared to * percent of Spanish speakers. The highest response rate for challenges for English speakers was 38 percent responding that communicating with their case worker was a challenge. The only challenges cited by Spanish speakers was * percent for both cultural barriers and waitlist time.

Looking at challenges by participant perception of staff helpfulness, despite 83 percent of participants indicating staff were in helpful in guiding them in the application process, those people still encountered at least one challenge during the child care financial assistance process. There were 67 percent of participants saying document re-submission was a challenge and 50 percent saying communication with their caseworker was a challenge.

Looking at area type, 66 percent of suburban participants cited at least one challenge during the child care financial assistance process, with 34 percent of suburban participants responding that communication with their caseworker was a challenge. There were 40 percent of urban participants that reported at least one challenge with 27 percent reporting communication with their caseworker as a challenge. The lowest rate was for rural participants with 31 percent reporting at least one challenge during the child care financial assistance process, with 23 percent reporting communication with their caseworker as a challenge.

QUESTION FOUR-B – Successes Encountered

Finally, participants were also asked about successes encountered with the question, “What were the steps you had to take to apply for child care financial assistance, and what successes if any did you encounter?” A little more than half, 52 percent, of the 60 participants responded to the question. Almost a third, 28 percent, reported that a clear outline of the application process was a success during the subsidy process. Communication with their caseworker was a success for 27 percent of the participants. Percentages do not sum to 100 percent since some participants are counted more than once because they provided multiple responses to multiple subcodes.

Looking at region, 73 percent of participants from northern California reported at least one success during the child care financial assistance process compared to 60 percent from southern California, 63 percent from mid-southern and central California. Having a clear outline of the application process was a success for 45 percent of participants from northern California and 40 percent of participants from mid-southern California. Communication with their caseworker was a success for 45 percent of participants from northern California and 33 percent of participants from southern California. The ability to submit documents electronically was a success for 47 percent of participants from southern California.

QUESTION FIVE – Improving the Child Care Financial Assistance Process

For the fifth question participants were asked, “How do you think your experience applying for child care financial assistance could have been improved?” A group of 60 individuals were asked about how to improve the child care financial assistance application process. There were 45 percent individuals that responded to this prompt. There were 35 percent of participants that either (1) reported reducing communication response time could improve the child care financial assistance process, (2) that regular communication updates could improve the application process, or (3) that making improvements to documentation could also help the application process. Percentages do not sum to 100 percent since some participants are counted more than once because they provided multiple responses.

Participants stated **many ways their experience** applying for financial assistance **could have been improved**

Humanize denial notices	*
Reduce phone/relay wait times	*
Refine worker competence/attitude	*
Expand Income Limits	*
Offer different ways to apply	*
Humanize communication	*
Provide clear explanations	*
Increase program marketing	*
Reduce/streamline documentation	*
Provide more updates	*
Reduce response time	*

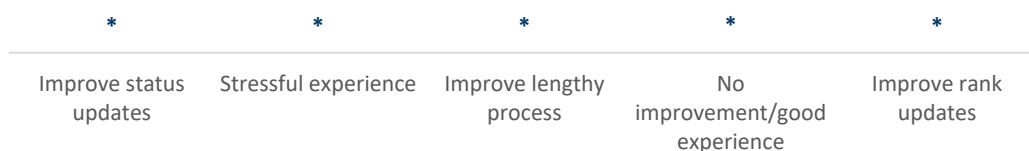
Looking at region, 67 percent of participants from southern California responded with at least one way to improve the child care financial assistance application process compared to 48 percent of participants from mid southern California, 33 percent from central California, and 18 percent from northern California. The need for faster communication response time was cited by 27 percent of participants from southern California compared to 25 percent from mid-southern and northern California and zero percent from central California.

Participants were asked to complete a survey prior to the listening sessions. One of the survey questions asked how helpful staff were during the application process. There were 50 percent of respondents that found staff unhelpful on the survey and these responded with at least one way to improve the child care financial assistance process. The 50 percent of respondents that said staff were unhelpful, 33 percent responded that communicating clear outlines would improve the child care financial assistance process. The 43 percent of respondents that found staff helpful on the survey responded with at least one way to improve the child care financial assistance process with * percent responding that reducing and streamlining the documentation process would help improve the child care financial assistance process. Half (50 percent) of the respondents that found staff neither helpful nor unhelpful and they responded with at least one way to improve the child care financial assistance process with 30 percent responding that faster communication response time would improve the child care financial assistance process.

QUESTION SIX – Waiting Lists

For the sixth question participants were asked, “If you encountered a waiting list, how do you feel about the process of being placed on the list?” A group of 60 individuals were asked about their waitlist experience. There were 23 percent of individuals that responded to prompt six. There were * percent of participants that reported that providing regular updates on the estimated time remaining on the waitlist along with explanations as how the waitlist is determined would improve the waitlist process. Reducing the wait time on the waitlist would improve the waitlist according to * percent of participants. There were * percent of participants that responded that their wait list experience was stressful due to the uncertainty and a pressing need for child care. Percentages do not sum to 100 percent since some participants are counted more than once because they provided multiple responses represented by more than one of the subcodes.

Participants **placed on a waiting** list felt it was **stressful** and that **improvements** were needed



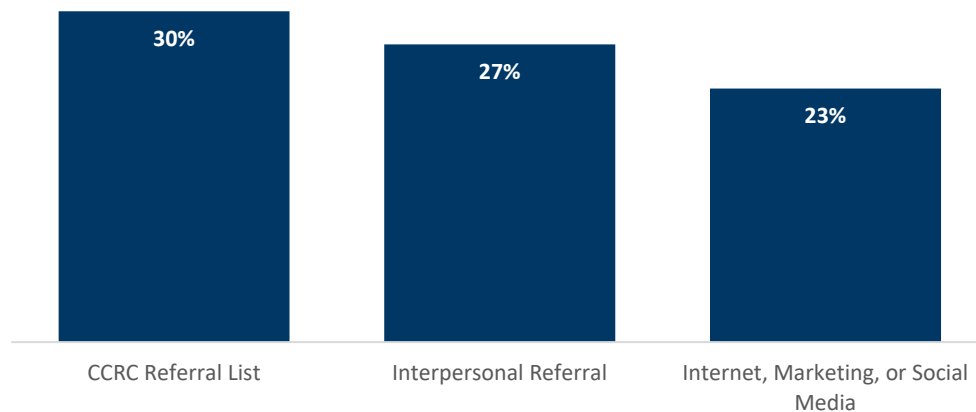
Looking at region, * percent of participants from northern California responded with at least one experience about being on the waiting list compared to * percent of people from southern California, 16 percent from the mid-southern California, and * percent from central California. The most cited theme or subcode for participants from northern California was a suggestion for improving the waitlist by providing waitlist status updates. This was also the most cited theme for participants from southern California where * percent of them offered the same improvement.

Of those participants that said they experienced a waitlist on the survey, 36 percent provided a response about their wait list experience during the listening sessions. The most common response was * percent that suggested providing wait list status updates. There were * percent of participants that reported a stressful experience while on the wait list, and * percent also suggested reducing the length of time on the wait list. Lastly, * percent of participants had a good experience or provided no suggestions.

QUESTION SEVEN – Tools Used in Finding Child Care Providers

For the seventh question, participants were asked “What tools or resources did you use to find your child care provider?”. Five major themes emerged from this question: R&R referral List, Interpersonal referral, Internet, Social Media, and Marketing. The top tool with 30 percent of responses involved using the R&R referral List to find a child care provider. While 27 percent of responses involved finding out through an interpersonal referral, such as a family member, a friend, or a coworker. Finding out through an Internet search, Social Media, or Marketing comprised of the remaining 23% of responses.

R&R referral lists and interpersonal referrals were the top two tools or resources participants used to find their child care provider

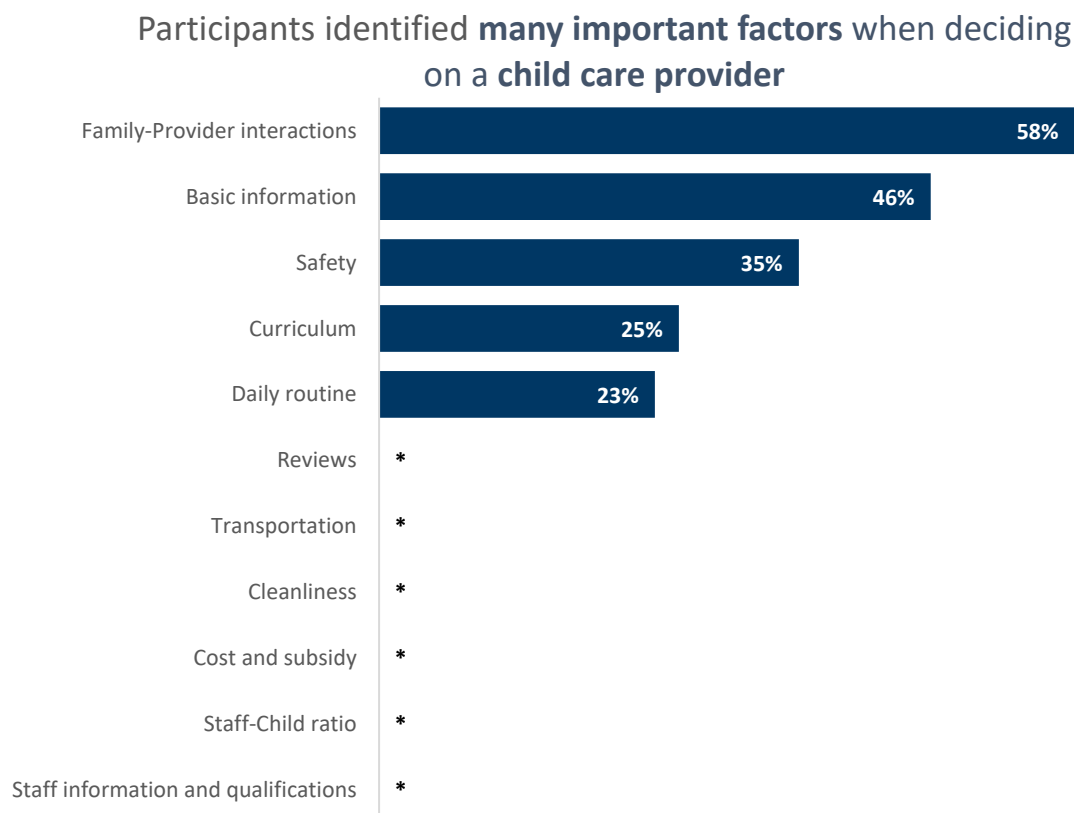


The referral list was the number one most used resource across all area types: Rural, Suburban, and Urban. And across all regions: Northern, Central, Mid-Southern, and Southern California. The referral list was especially useful for Spanish-speakers with * percent of Spanish-speaking participants noting the referral list as the most common resource used to find a child care provider. However, using the referral list did not impact participant’s ease/difficulty in finding a provider. Participants saying that it was easy or difficult both listed the referral list as the number one resource used.

Looking at region, the referral list provided by the agency was the most common resource used in Northern (40 percent), Central (75 percent), and Mid-Southern (43 percent) California. While participants living in Southern California mentioned an interpersonal referral (31 percent) as the most common resource used. Neither Northern nor Central California respondents mentioned marketing as a resource used to find their provider. Only participants living in Suburban areas mentioned Social Media as a resource. Participants living in a Rural area did not mention marketing or Social Media as a resource used.

QUESTION EIGHT – Important Factors in Choosing a Child Care Provider

For question 8, participants were asked, “What was important to you when making a decision on which child care provider to leave your child or children with?” 48 participants gave 133 responses that were categorized into 10 major themes (with a 10 percent response rate or higher (4 participants mentioning it or higher)). The majority of participants’ responses, 58 percent, listed factors that had to do with the child care provider’s interactions with either the parent and/or the child.



“I needed a second parent is what I needed. I needed a co-parent. I needed someone who was going to be me when I wasn't there, so that was really difficult to find.”

– Participant

The next most common important factors were categorized in basic information, which included comments regarding location, hours of operation, and whether the provider was an in-home day care or a center. This prompt had a response rate of 46 percent and participants mentioned at least one basic piece of information, with hours of operation the most common mentioned. While cost and child care financial assistance information only had * percent of responses, participants that did mention it as an important factor also mentioned that it was the most important factor for them.

“It's hard, you know, depending on someone to watch your kids, especially when your kids are so young and they can't talk, they can't defend their self. So it it's important to me to make sure that I'm able to trust the child care workers.”

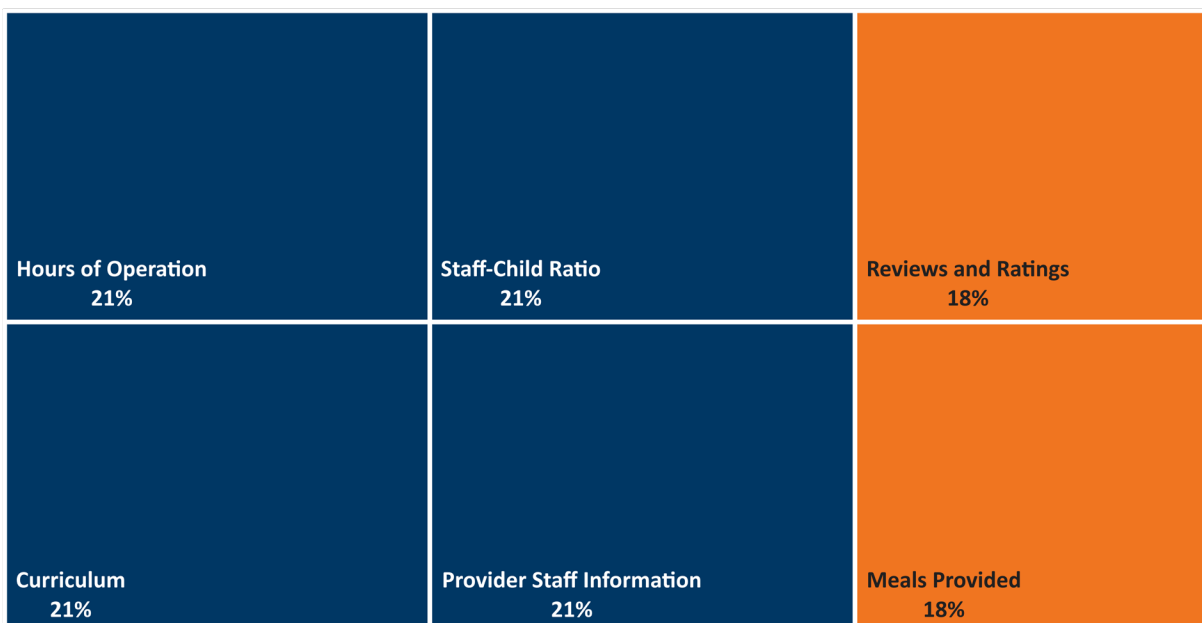
– Participant

Other notable mentions not shown on the chart, were language (* percent), violations (* percent), potty training (* percent), space available (* percent), and discipline (* percent).

QUESTION NINE – Useful Information to Include in Online Resources

For the ninth question, participants were asked “What kinds of information would be useful for you to have in an online website for understanding child care options and finding child care?”. In total, participants gave 68 responses and grouped into common themes. The top four themes, with 21 percent of participants responses, were: Provider-Staff Information, Hours of Operation, Curriculum, and Staff-Child Ratio. The Provider-Staff Information theme included wanting to know if staff are certified (such as CPR) or have credentials, as well as personal information on staff, such as pictures and short biographies that include the person’s experience with children; another top theme was Hours of Operation, where participants wanted to know the specific days and times the provider is open to receiving children for child care. Curriculum was also a top theme, where participants were asking for specifics on what learning style is implemented for the children and what specifically is taught to each age group. Lastly, Staff-Child Ratio was a top theme, where participants wanted to know how many children were being cared for compared to how many staff, as well as the classroom or group size (number of children) in general.

Participants identified **many kinds of information** that would be useful **to have in an online website** for understanding child care options and finding child care



Pictures	*
Transportation Provided	*
Language	*
Up-to-Date Information	*
Licensing Information	*
Special Needs Accommodations	*
Links to Resources	*
Additional Contact Information	*
Violations	*
Openings Available	*
Cost and Subsidy Accepted	*

Responses by Region and Area Type: there was equal representation from regions across California with 55 percent of participants who live in Northern California, 55 percent of participants who live in Central California, 56 percent who live in Mid-Southern California, and 53 percent of participants who live in Southern California. However, there was slightly more representation from participants who live in Rural areas of California, with 69 percent of total participants living in Rural areas responding to the question, compared to 60 percent and 49 percent, from Urban and Suburban areas respectively.

Responses by Region and Area Type: there was equal representation from regions across California with 55 percent of participants who live in Northern California, 55 percent of participants who live in Central California, 56 percent who live in Mid-Southern California, and 53 percent of participants who live in Southern California. However, there was slightly more representation from participants who live in Rural areas of California, with 69 percent of total participants living in Rural areas responding to the question, compared to 60 percent and 49 percent, from Urban and Suburban areas respectively.

“But when you're trying to really be specific with what the needs entail for your child so that way, you're limiting how many interviews you have to do and you can manage your time accordingly checking out these facilities, there isn't that option out.”

– Participant

QUESTION TEN- Closing

The final question in each listening session encapsulated any other feedback parents had. Most sessions had little discussion during this question, but all feedback was coded and categorized under each of the prior questions where applicable.

Recommendations

The listening sessions present a clear picture of the need parents have for the Child Care Connect online website. The support for the website as well as recommendations on the construction of areas of the website are listed below. Each set of recommendations is categorized by the five AB 2960 requirements that guide the future buildout of the website.

Domains

I. Information on Early Learning and Care (ELC) programs and eligibility requirements

CCRC discovered that some participants are using the internet for child care-related searches. A fifth (17 percent) of participants said that they learned that child care financial assistance was available through an internet search, with many using a search engine such as Google as a starting point. However, zero percent of participants mentioned mychildcareplan.org as part of their internet search process. The websites they did use did not contain key components they needed, making it harder to find information. This presents an opportunity for strategic marketing and website configurations to bridge the gap between parents and information on Early Learning Care (ELC) programs and eligibility requirements.

First, CCRC recommends an exhaustive marketing plan of the online website and tools. Parents need to be aware that the website is a tool for it to be effective to help them in their journey to find and pay for child care. The marketing plan should involve advertising on television, radio, internet, billboards, flyers,

and newsletters. Physical advertising must be tactical, making sure that the ads are in places where parents with children commonly frequent such as elementary schools and pediatric clinics.

In doing so, a marketing plan will help parents who had a harder time applying for child care financial assistance. Although * percent of all participants found out about child care financial assistance through marketing, participants who said the process for applying for child care financial assistance was “difficult” were more likely to have found out about the availability of child care financial assistance through marketing, with * percent saying so compared to * percent of participants who said the process was “easy” and zero percent of participants who said the process was “neither easy nor difficult”. Furthermore, participants who found the process “difficult” were a bit more likely to have found out about the availability of child care financial assistance through an internet search, with 27 percent saying so compared to 20 percent who said the process was “easy” and zero percent who said the process was “neither easy nor difficult”.

Second, CCRC recommends a methodological approach to ensure all information on the website is accurate. Participants (nine percent) indicated that up-to-date information would be useful to have on an online website for understanding child care options and finding child care. This includes all relevant provider data such as location, space availability, licensing, etc. It also includes program and financial assistance information since * percent of participants said that information on the cost and whether child care financial assistance was accepted was important information to have on a website as well. Therefore, implementing a process to regularly update data is important for parents seeking information, especially eligibility criteria that can change each year or due to fiscal policy.

Third, CCRC recommends having a section of the website dedicated to external information and resources. When asked what kinds of information would be useful to have on an online website for understanding child care options and finding child care, * percent of participants said links to resources. These links would be valuable to parents with their journey of finding and paying for child care. However, the links do not have to be directly related to child care. One parent, for example, said that it would be nice for the agency’s website to have information on diapers. Therefore, the information and resources displayed on the website should comprehensively focus on helping parents with their children’s needs beyond solely child care. Given that the current mychildcareplan.org already has a resources webpage, and Child Care Connect will grow on this platform, this recommendation would require mostly small modifications to the website to include local links to resources such as county 2-1-1 programs.

Is there any recommendation that we haven't talked about?

“...I know it's for the children, but it would be nice if they had on the website a place where they can have resources for the parents. Because if they are in need, I don't know if you give diapers, but other organizations give them, so it would be nice if you could share that information with the parents..”

– Participant

Fourth, CCRC recommends having a variety of communication methods that parents can use to ask questions when using the website. When asked what kinds of information would be useful to have on an online website for understanding child care options and finding child care, * percent of participants said

additional contact information. While telephone contact information is readily available, parents suggested alternative communication channels such as email, live chat, and video chat. It is worth noting that mychildcareplan.org has a contact webpage with an array of communication methods, and that these are expected to be inherited by Child Care Connect. However, communication methods for each individual provider varies. Ensuring a variety of communication methods on the website, including individual providers, allows parents flexibility when reaching out and gives them the opportunity to choose the communication method they find the most comfortable.

We can significantly increase the visibility and usage of the Child Care Connect tool by implementing a well-rounded marketing strategy and a website containing key components parents seek, and thereby disseminate information on ELC programs and eligibility requirements.

II. The opportunity to connect with local ELC providers

It is evident from engaging with parents directly that families seeking child care services need a comprehensive online child care portal. It is essential that the portal connects directly with local Early Learning and Care (ELC) providers so that it achieves the outcome of being a comprehensive online child care portal. CCRC recommends the website provide the opportunity to connect with local child care providers. The website offers an opportunity to alleviate many of the hardships experienced by parents when researching providers by connecting directly with providers. Allowing providers to provide information relevant to their child care will ensure information is kept up to date, ensure all providers in the area are listed, and ensure the information parents are looking for is easily found. Additionally, parents specifically noted it would be helpful to have additional avenues to communicate with providers, the website could offer a direct chat feature for each provider.

Many participants, 68 percent, found out about child care financial assistance through a personal referral or another social program they were currently enrolled in. This implies most participants that find out about child care financial assistance are either already in a program that will connect them to financial assistance or know someone who already is receiving child care financial assistance. This creates an inaccessibility to parents that do not fall within these categories, leaving many families who would qualify for financial assistance programs unaware that they exist and that they might be eligible.

Only * percent of participants used the internet to find their current provider. While the referral list provided to parents was the number one most used resource across California and in all area types (Rural, Suburban, and Urban), with over 30 percent of participants mentioning it as the one they used, parents often spoke about their frustrations with the list. Many participants noted that the list was often inconclusive, missing many providers in their area, as well as outdated, and missing critical important factors families look for when researching providers that meet the needs of their families. There were over 70 percent of participants that listed at least one important factor in choosing a provider as difficult to find when researching child care providers.

Participants described family-provider interactions as the most important factor when choosing a child care provider, with 58 percent mentioning it. Family-provider interactions largely refer to getting to know the provider. The second most important factor for parents included basic information about the provider such as location and hours of operation. Yet, 46 percent of participants mentioned this information was difficult to find when researching providers.

Lastly, 62 percent of participants were placed on a waitlist to receive financial assistance and * percent were placed on the waitlist for over six months. Child care provider waitlists further compound this issue as participants are faced with the decision to pay out of pocket to get the provider they want or miss the opportunity to get their preferred provider and settle on another one that has space available. There were at least * percent of participants that spoke directly about not being able or being limited in the provider they could choose due to the waitlists from child care financial assistance and the provider. Consequently, * percent of participants say they are not satisfied with their current provider. Thus, having direct access to up-to-date information on a provider's enrollment regarding spaces available and waitlist would greatly benefit parents.

CCRC recommends the website include the following categories for all providers, as these were the most important for parents and also reported as difficult to find by parents when researching providers: Location, hours of operation, staff qualifications, curriculum, cost, reviews from other parents, languages, and culture. Additionally, the most important factors parents spoke about when choosing a provider involved provider-family interactions. Providing an opportunity for parents to connect directly to providers allows parents to start communication with providers early on and expedite the process of choosing a provider.

III. The ability to use an online eligibility screening tool to assess eligibility for ELC services

In discussions with participants, it was learned that many of them relied on the internet to learn what Early Learning Care (ELC) services they qualified for. Participants (17 percent) said they found out that child care financial assistance was available through an internet search. However, only * percent of participants said they found out that they themselves were eligible to receive child care financial assistance through the internet, either through search engines and their results or using online tools like child care cost calculators. Participants who said it was “difficult” to find out what child care financial assistance programs they qualified for were more likely to use the internet to find out, with * percent saying so compared to * percent of participants who said it was “easy” and zero percent of participants who said it was “neither easy nor difficult” or “no opinion”. Thus, providing an online eligibility screening tool to assess eligibility for ELC services is crucial for parents who start their journey to find child care online.

CCRC recommends implementing an online eligibility screening tool that parents can use to determine if they qualify for child care financial assistance. Parents cited both intricate online calculator tools and simple textual income requirements. A simple approach involving text or a table that outlines the eligibility requirements is recommended to quickly get this tool online. However, a more intricate tool such as an online calculator that is easy to use would provide more nuanced information based on the unique circumstances of families and a much better user experience. Therefore, if resources are limited, it is recommended to start with a simple eligibility screening tool so that parents can have access to this tool right away. CCRC recommends an online screening calculator in the long term that considers more information to assess what ELC services for which parents might qualify.

CCRC also recommends saving any information parents input into the online eligibility tool to automatically complete corresponding fields on an online application. When asked what could also help improve the experience of applying for financial assistance, ten percent of participants said that making improvements to documentation. Many expressed frustrations with having to resubmit documents they had already provided. Parents had a more positive attitude toward the application process when

information they provided was not lost and wasn't repeatedly asked for. Hence, parents would greatly benefit from an online eligibility tool that saves the information parents input and later uses it to automatically complete parts of an online application.

Parents who use the internet to search for child care options would greatly benefit from an online eligibility screening tool. The screening tool would ensure that they have as much information as possible from their online search. Taking it a step further by saving and reusing the information they provide on the screening tool would provide a better user experience.

How did you find out that you were eligible to receive child care financial assistance?

"I read the requirement on the [agency] website, and I applied. And after some time, I was told I was approved. The estimated income of what you would be eligible for was stated on the website."

– Participant

"I applied online. I did the calculator thing to see if I would be eligible, then I applied online. [It] said to download a Care Connect app to just monitor the application process."

– Participant

IV. A way to connect with local R&R agencies and Alternative Payment Programs to help with assessing and selecting child care options

Less than half of families who are eligible for subsidized child care access it. Families seeking child care need a centralized online portal that can connect them to not only child care providers, but also alternative payment programs and Resource & Referral agencies. The online portal should provide parents the ability to access providers in their area and connect parents to valuable resources in order to meet parents where they are at since families seeking child care do not know about these benefits available to them. CCRC recommends the online portal include accessible and user-friendly information that enables parents to connect with their local Resource & Referral agency and subsequent alternative payment programs.

There were over 20 percent of participants that spoke directly about needing more information about financial assistance programs available to them, specifically about informing parents seeking child care that they may qualify for subsidized child care. Twenty-seven percent of participants said it was either difficult or very difficult to find out what child care financial assistance programs they qualified for, and 17 percent of participants said it was both difficult to find their financial assistance program and child care provider. The website offers a unique opportunity to connect parents with much needed information about financial assistance programs and other social services; by doing this, we go beyond AB 2960 compliance to truly meet the needs of parents. * percent of participants found out about child care financial assistance through their provider and * percent of participants found out they were eligible through their provider. ECL providers represent a very unique and opportune location to provide parents with child care financial assistance information. Many parents are unaware that child care

financial assistance exists, yet they still need child care. The online portal offers a much needed platform to assess and select a child care provider for those parents searching for child care services that are already connected to a Resource & Referral agency. Over 30 percent of participants used the referral list provided by their Resource & Referral agency, however, many who used the list spoke about a number of pain points that lead to frustration and difficulty in finding a provider. Parents noted that the list did not have all of the providers available to them in their area; additionally, the list did not provide critical information they needed in assessing what child care provider meets the unique needs of their family. * percent of participants mentioned that acceptance of child care financial assistance was an important factor, but if parents did not use the referral list, or the provider is not on the referral list, they would have to find this information through other means. They would need to either check the provider's website to see if the information is listed, otherwise they would need to contact the provider directly, adding additional steps to finding this information.

Based on information gathered from parents, CCRC recommends the following alignments on how an online early care and learning portal could be designed to improve on pain points throughout their journey not just of finding a child care provider, but also crucial financial assistance agencies and programs: Ability to enter address to find their local R&R/APP agency that serves them; clear information presented by each child care provider on accepting child care financial assistance.

V. Access to placement on waiting lists for subsidized child care programs.

Participants were prompted to share challenges, successes, and suggestions for improvement of the child care financial assistance process. Participants discussed their experiences about being placed on a wait list. Most participants, two-thirds (67 percent), reported being placed on a wait list on the quantitative survey administered prior to the listening session. Based on the shared experiences provided by participants during the listening sessions, CCRC offers the following recommendations to improve the user experience of being placed on a waiting list: Provide an estimated amount of time one should expect to be on the wait list, provide their rank and an explanation for how they are ranked and placed on the wait list, provide regular updates on the status of the wait list, and try to reduce time on the wait list.

These recommendations have their basis in the fact that of the participants that discussed challenges during the child care financial assistance process, 23 percent mentioned uncertainty about being on the wait list, * percent mentioned the ranking system, and ten percent their time waiting on the wait list. A notable success about the child care financial assistance process as a whole and applicable to the waiting list is having a clear outline of the child care financial assistance application process with 55 percent of those participants that mentioned having success during the child care financial assistance process saying a clear outline was a success. Two suggestions for improvement that participants had about the child care financial assistance process in its entirety and directly applicable to the wait list were reducing response time to communication (30 percent) and regular updates (26 percent). Unsurprisingly, the top suggestions were suggestions for implementing regular wait list status updates (50 percent) and reducing wait time on the list (29 percent).

We should extend this clarity of expectations about the application process to the wait list by providing updated wait list time estimates and regular updates about the participant's status on the wait list. This will obviate the need for participants to call agencies with inquiries about the wait list. The

improvements garnered from this process improvement will not only alleviate the stress of uncertainty from participants placed on the waiting list but also from the agency staff who must field this volume of calls and other communications from understandably inquisitive participants.

Next Steps/Future Work

The listening sessions conducted as part of this study highlight the pressing need for an improved website dedicated to informing parents about subsidized child care programs. These listening sessions revealed the challenges and complexities parents face in navigating the child care system. The feedback and insights gathered underscore the importance of creating a more user-friendly and accessible online platform. This platform should aim to simplify the journey for parents seeking subsidized child care, providing them with the essential information and guidance needed to make informed decisions for their families. There are several recommendations for future research that could help provide additional information to help with building the Child Care Connect website.

Involving a broader demographic in future listening sessions could provide richer insights. Expanding the audience to include men, non-binary individuals, and non-English/Spanish speakers would allow for a more comprehensive understanding of varied child care experiences and needs. This approach could help in tailoring services and resources to better accommodate a wider array of family structures and cultural backgrounds.

Regarding the new website, conducting user experience (UX) testing with both parents and child care providers could offer valuable feedback. This step could identify potential usability issues and highlight areas for improvement, making the website more accessible and efficient for its users. Gathering input from those who will regularly use the site ensures that it evolves in a way that is genuinely helpful and intuitive.

Lastly, enhancing collaboration with CDSS and Resource & Referral (R&R) agencies could greatly improve the information provided on the website and address parent concerns with the accuracy of the child care lists they are given. This partnership could focus on ensuring the accuracy, relevance, and helpfulness of the content, thereby making it a more valuable resource for parents and providers alike. Such collaboration might also facilitate the sharing of up-to-date child care information and trends, enhancing the overall quality of the resources offered. This collaboration would give CDSS an opportunity to support providers in updating their data and conduct outreach regarding the benefits to the provider's business, providing them an incentive to participate.

Appendices

Appendix A. Recruitment Survey Questions

Name

First Name Last Name

Email

email

Phone Number

Phone number

Please enter your zip code

Zip code

1. Have you ever used or applied for childcare financial assistance?

Yes, I am currently receiving it

Yes, I've received it in the past

I am currently in the application process for it

I've completed an application, but have been put on a waitlist

I've applied in the past, but was declined

No

I'm not sure

2. Have you ever used the website mychildcareplan.org? (prior use is not required for participation)

Yes

No

3. What is your race/ethnicity? (Check all that apply)

Black / African / African - Caribbean / African American

Arab / Middle Eastern

Asian / Asian American

Latino / Latina / Latinx / Latine / Hispanic

American Indian / Alaskan Native / Indigenous

White / Caucasian / European American

Native Hawaiian/ or other Pacific Islander

4. Are you still seeking new child care?

Yes

No

5. These listening sessions will be conducted virtually over Zoom. Do you have a device you can log on with an internet connection, camera, and microphone?

Yes

No

6. What is your preferred language?

English
Spanish
Mandarin
American Sign Language
Other

7. Please select your gender

Female
Male
Non-Binary
Other

**8. If selected to participate, what time of day are you available to attend a 2 hour listening session?
(Check all that apply)**

Mornings
Mid-Day
Evenings
Weekends
Other

Appendix B. Quantitative Survey Questions

Name:

First Name Last Name

What is your age?

Under 18
18-25
26-35
36-45
46-55
56-65
Over 65

How many children are you the primary caretaker (e.g. parent, guardian) for?
(Open-Ended Question)

How easy or difficult was it for you to find a child care provider?

Very Easy
Easy
Neither Easy nor Difficult
Difficult
Very Difficult

How satisfied or unsatisfied are or were you with your child care provider?

Very Satisfied
Satisfied
Neither Satisfied nor Unsatisfied
Unsatisfied
Very Unsatisfied

What factors are important for you when deciding on a child care provider?

Location
Cost
Hours of Operation
Curriculum
Staff Qualifications (e.g., licenses, degrees, accreditations)
Reviews from other parents
Referral from my Resource and Referral Agency
Culture
Languages
Other

Which of these factors were difficult for you find when researching child care providers?

Location
Cost
Hours of Operation

Curriculum
Staff Qualifications (e.g., licenses, degrees, accreditations)
Reviews from other parents
Referral from my Resource and Referral Agency
Culture
Languages
Other

How did you find your child care provider? If you used a website, tell us about the website and how you used it.

(Open-Ended Question)

How easy or difficult was it to find an agency to help you pay for child care?

Very Easy
Easy
Neither Easy no Difficult
Difficult
Very Difficult

How did you find your child care financial assistance agency? If you used a website, tell us about the website and how you used it.

(Open-Ended Question)

How easy or difficult was it to find out what child care financial assistance programs you qualified for?

Very Easy
Easy
Neither Easy no Difficult
Difficult
Very Difficult

How easy or difficult was the process for applying for child care financial assistance?

Very Easy
Easy
Neither Easy no Difficult
Difficult
Very Difficult

When applying for child care financial assistance, how helpful were the staff guiding you through the application process?

Very Easy
Easy
Neither Easy no Difficult
Difficult
Very Difficult

If you were placed on a waitlist, about how long were you on the waitlist for before receiving financial assistance?

Under a month
One to Two months
Three to Six months
Over six months
I'm still on a waitlist
I'm not sure
I was not placed on a waitlist

Appendix C. Listening Session Questions

Domains: (All – Q: (10), (11))

- A. Information on ELC programs (Q: (1), (2), (5))
- B. The opportunity to connect with ELC providers (Q: (1), (3), (7), (8), (9))
- C. The ability to use an online eligibility screening tool to assess eligibility for ELC services (Q: (2), (4), (5))
- D. A way to connect with local R&R agencies and Alternative Payment providers to help with assessing and selecting childcare options ((1), (2), (3), (7), (8), (9))
- E. Access to placement on waiting lists for subsidized childcare programs (Q: (1), (4), (5), (6))

Questions:

- 1. How did you find out that childcare financial assistance was available?**
 - a. Probes
 - b. Insights
 - i. Where did families find CCFA?
 - ii. What specific resources did parents cite?
 - iii. What pain points did families bring up about finding CCFA?
- 2. How did you find out that you were eligible to receive childcare financial assistance?**
 - a. Probe: Did you find out this information online or from another resource? What was it?
 - b. Insights
 - i. Where did they find eligibility?
 - ii. What pain points did families bring up about eligibility?
 - iii. Is there evidence to support the benefit of an online eligibility screening tool to assess eligibility?
- 3. How did you discover the agency that provided you with childcare financial assistance?**
 - a. Probe
 - b. Insights
 - i. What vector did families find the agency through? (e.g. website, social connection, marketing push from agency, other resource)
 - ii. Were there any differences between finding this from the prior steps?
 - iii. Is there evidence to support the benefit of an online website offering a way to connect with local R&R agencies and Alternative Payment providers to help with assessing and selecting childcare options?
- 4. What were the steps you had to take to apply for childcare financial assistance?**
 - a. Probes
 - i. Probe: What was challenging about the process?
 - ii. Probe: What did you like about the process?
 - b. Insights
 - i. What are common pathways people experience?
 - ii. What made the experience easier for families?

- iii. What made the experience harder for families?
- 5. **How do you think your experience applying for childcare financial assistance could have been improved?**
 - a. Probes
 - i. Probe: What would have made your life easier?
 - b. Insights?
 - i. What improvements did parents suggest?
- 6. **If you encountered a waiting list, how do you feel about the process of being placed on the list?**
 - a. Probes
 - i. Probe: What would have made being placed on the waiting list easier on you?
 - b. Insights
 - i. Is there evidence to support the benefit of an online waitlist offering access to placement on waiting lists for subsidized childcare programs?
 - ii. What were the pain points of being on a waitlist?
- 7. **What tools or resources did you use to find your child care provider? (e.g. internet search, yelp, R&R referral, friend or family referral)**
 - a. Probes
 - i. Probe: What was the most useful to you?
 - ii. Probe: What was the least useful to you?
 - b. Insights
 - i. What were the common tools parents cited?
 - ii. What were the benefits of the tools they used?
 - iii. What were the downsides of the tools they used?
- 8. **What was important to you when making a decision on which childcare provider to leave your child or children with?**
 - a. Probes
 - i. Probe: What information would have been useful to know?
 - b. Insights
 - i. What were the traits parents cited?
 - ii. What traits would we recommend be listed alongside a provider's information on the ELC portal?
- 9. **What kinds of information would be useful for you to have in an online website for understanding child care options and finding childcare? (such as mychildcareplan.org)**
 - a. Probe:
 - b. Insights
 - i. What information did parents feel would be useful?
- 10. **Is there anything else you would recommend that we haven't talked about?**

Appendix D. Listening Session Protocol

Introduction (Ten min):

Introduce yourself as people join. If session is not at capacity, give up to 5 minutes for participants to join. After 5 minutes have passed, Lead will start the dialogue while the Aide calls any missing participants and handles participant technical issues.

“Thank you for joining us today. This discussion is part of a project where we are interested in your experiences with child care financial assistance, also called child care subsidy, and experiences finding a child care provider. Your experiences will help us provide feedback to the California Department of Social Services and help guide them in building their child care website, mychildcareplan.org.

My name is _____, and my role here is to ask questions and listen. I won’t be participating in the conversation; I’ll be moving the discussion from one topic to the next. *Since we have a limited amount of time, I may interrupt if the discussion begins to stray from the topic.* If there are questions that we cannot answer during the session today, we will follow up with you afterwards by e-mail or phone.

With me today, we have some other staff who will be helping me run this session:

This is _____.

Aide: “Hi, I’m here as our session aide. I’m available to help with any technology problems that may come up, and I’ll be monitoring the Zoom chat for us. If a topic comes up where you feel more comfortable sharing through text, we encourage you to use the Zoom chat. I’ll occasionally be voicing text from the chat, but will otherwise not be participating in the discussions.”

Thank you _____. We also have _____ with us today.

Note Taker: “Hi everyone. I’m here to take notes on today’s session. I won’t be participating in the discussion to make sure I can record everyone’s feedback accurately.”

Thank you, _____. Before we get started, please take a moment to enable your video feed if you don’t have it on yet.

Develop group norms (Ten min):

- First off, the information you provide today will be kept confidential. When pulled together, the information will be reported out in aggregate form meaning we will be identifying themes from a combination of all the groups. Any quotes used will not identify the speaker or names of anyone you have interacted with.
- In order to make sure everyone’s voices are heard, please mute your microphone if you are not talking. You are free to unmute and respond to questions as we ask them, though.
- There are also other ways to participate in the session today. If you’re more comfortable with raising your hand, you can do so through Zoom and we will call on you to speak when we are ready. You can also use the Zoom chat to type out your responses, and our aide will voice them periodically through the session.
- Finally, we ask what is learned today can leave this session, but the specifics should stay here. We ask that you all agree not to share information from this session that could identify another member of this group. We want everyone to feel safe in this space to share and be present.

- Thank you everyone for showing me your faces. If you have not had a chance to yet, please turn your video on if you have not. If you are having technical problems with video, please let us know in the chat and ____ will assist you.
- Are there any other agreements others would like to put forward?
 - Have everyone raise their hand in agreement.

Ice breaker: (Five-Ten min)

To start we are going to have you introduce yourselves. Tell us your name, and one of your favorite childhood meals.

Conversation Questions: (70-90 min)

General Prompts: Can you elaborate? Say a little more.

1. How did you find out that childcare financial assistance was available?
 - a. Probe: Did you see an ad or did someone tell you about it?
2. How did you find out that you were eligible to receive childcare financial assistance?
 - a. Probe: Did you find out this information online or from another resource? What was it?
3. How did you discover the agency that provided you with childcare financial assistance?
 - a. Probe: How did you connect with the agency?
4. What were the steps you had to take to apply for childcare financial assistance?
 - a. Probe: What was challenging about the process?
 - b. Probe: What did you like about the process?
 - i. What was easy about the process?
5. How do you think your experience applying for childcare financial assistance could have been improved?
 - a. Probe: What would have made your life easier?
6. If you encountered a waiting list, how do you feel about the process of being placed on the list?
 - a. Probe: What would have made being placed on the waiting list easier on you?
7. What tools or resources did you use to find your child care provider? (e.g. internet search, yelp, R&R referral, friend or family referral)
 - a. Probe: What was the most useful to you?
8. What was important to you when making a decision on which childcare provider to leave your child or children with?
 - a. Probe: What information would have been useful to know?
 - b. Probe: Was there anything you didn't consider that you would the next time?
9. What kinds of information would be useful for you to have in an online website for understanding child care options and finding childcare? (such as mychildcareplan.org)
 - a. Probe: What information should a website have so you know about the child care that is available to you?
10. In hindsight, what did you not consider when choosing a provider-but would now
11. Is there anything else you would recommend that we haven't talked about?
12. Anything else?

De-Brief: (Five-Ten min)

Thank you so much for taking the time to talk with us about your personal experiences. We are grateful for each of you, because of these focus groups we will be able to share a much clearer picture of what it's like to find child care financial assistance and a provider for your family.

I want to be sure to take some time to see whether you have any questions or concerns about this discussion. *Be sure to give people time to reflect.*

Finally, I want to let you know that we will be sending your gift cards to the email address that you registered for the focus group with once we have verified completion of the survey we sent prior to this group. Gift cards should be sent within the next two weeks. If you have any questions or concerns about this session or the survey, please feel free to use the chat box or email me at name@ccrcca.org

Protocol Checklist:**Recruitment**

- Randomly select 15 participants per time slot to recruit
- Ensure final recruitment list has a representative spread of locations in California
- **Facilitator:** Create zoom meeting link for your scheduled meeting. Ensure that closed captioning, interpretation, auto-recording, auto-mute of participants are all enabled.
- E-mail first 12 participants for each session seven days prior to the session
- Fill remaining spots with the remaining recruitment pool for each session
- Send quantitative survey to participants alongside the recruitment e-mail
- Send reminder e-mail to participants three days prior to session
- Send reminder e-mail to participants one day prior to session
- Send reminder e-mail to participants 15 minutes prior to session

In-SessionAll:

- In the event the Facilitator drops out of the meeting, the Aide should step in to facilitate the meeting until the Facilitator is able to rejoin.
- Rename your Zoom name to your session role and name.

Facilitator:

- Start meeting 15 minutes prior to start time.
- Verify that recording has started on Zoom.
- Turn on Closed Captioning in the meeting. You can turn the visual captions off if needed.
- Greet participants as they join the meeting.
- Start meeting by :05 at the latest as needed to allow participants to join.
- Facilitate session utilizing the script.
- At end of session, click Save Transcript in the Closed Captioning section.

Aide:

- Pull up the recruitment contact information for the session.
- Join meeting 15 minutes prior to start time.
- Double-check that the facilitator has turned on recording and closed captioning.
- After the meeting start time, keep track of attendance.
- By :05, call or text any participants who have not joined the meeting yet.
- Assist any participants having technology issues. Start with attempting to chat via Zoom, and if that fails text or call the participant.
- As participants chat using Zoom's text chat, find opportunities to echo them in voice chat.
- At end of session, click Save Transcript in the Closed Captioning section.

Note Taker:

- Join meeting 15 minutes prior to start time.
- Keep your video on for introductions, then turn video off.
- Keep 100 percent of your focus on taking notes.
- At end of session, click Save Transcript in the Closed Captioning section.

Appendix E. State Regions

Central California: Fresno County, Inyo County, Kings County, Madera County, Mariposa County, Merced County, Monterey County, San Benito County, San Mateo County, Santa Clara County, Santa Cruz County, Stanislaus County, Tulare County

Mid-Southern California: Kern County, Los Angeles County, San Luis Obispo County, Santa Barbara County, Ventura County

Northern California: Alameda County, Alpine County, Amador County, Butte County, Calaveras County, Colusa County, Contra Costa County, Del Norte County, El Dorado County, Glenn County, Humboldt County, Lake County, Lassen County, Marin County, Mendocino County, Modoc County, Mono County, Napa County, Nevada County, Placer County, Plumas County, Sacramento County, San Francisco County, San Joaquin County, Shasta County, Sierra County, Siskiyou County, Solano County, Sonoma County, Sutter County, Tehama County, Trinity County, Tuolumne County, Yolo County, Yuba County

Southern California: Imperial County, Orange County, Riverside County, San Bernardino County, San Diego County